

SHOPSCENE / SHOPPAGE

Updated Business Model for Zimbabwe

*Local commerce discovery • Short-form shopping video • Geolocal search • Local advertising •
Creator and affiliate commerce*

Strategic working model — July 2026

Central thesis

Do not build another generic marketplace. Build Zimbabwe's local commerce graph and advertising network: a platform that converts fragmented Facebook, WhatsApp, short-video and offline-market activity into structured products, verified sellers, measurable leads, local media inventory and transaction-ready demand.

Executive summary

Strategic repositioning. Shopscene should evolve from a conventional multi-vendor discovery platform into Zimbabwe's local commerce media infrastructure. Its role is to substitute the commercial functions currently performed by Facebook Marketplace, Facebook Pages and Groups, WhatsApp catalogues, Google commercial search, Google Maps, TikTok/Reels/Shorts, classifieds, influencers and informal market directories.

Product split. ShopPage is the merchant operating layer. Shopscene is the buyer-discovery and media layer. Shopscene Ads is the local advertising exchange. Shopscene Creators is the affiliate and content-distribution layer. Markets are digital containers for malls, flea markets, districts, supplier clusters and commercial communities.

Winning wedge. Launch in Harare with Home, Power and Building: solar, batteries, inverters, electrical, plumbing, hardware, building materials, furniture, appliances and related services. This cluster supports high-intent search, quote requests, video demonstrations, local availability and diaspora purchasing.

Economic engine. Revenue should come from subscriptions, local advertising, managed campaigns, qualified leads, catalogue digitisation, creator commissions, market subscriptions, sponsorships and data intelligence. Native checkout should be added only after freshness, trust, response quality and repeat demand are validated.

Layer	Primary user	Core job
ShopPage	Merchants and sellers	Operate a catalogue, storefront, content, leads and promotions
Shopscene	Shoppers and buyers	Discover products, videos, vendors, markets and nearby deals
Shopscene Ads	Merchants, brands and markets	Buy measurable Zimbabwean commercial attention
Shopscene Creators	Creators, affiliates and group admins	Produce shoppable content and earn from demand
Markets	Malls, districts and trader clusters	Digitise a physical or community market as a searchable destination

1. Strategic repositioning

Previous framing

Shopscene was framed as a mobile-first multi-vendor commerce discovery and vendor-growth platform. That remains correct, but it does not fully express the opportunity.

Updated framing

Updated definition

Shopscene is Zimbabwe's local commerce media network: a geolocal product-discovery engine, short-video shopping feed, vendor-catalogue infrastructure, local advertising exchange, affiliate-commerce network and market-in-market platform.

The platform should absorb and improve the commercial functions currently scattered across:

- Facebook Marketplace, business pages and public selling groups.
- WhatsApp catalogues, statuses and enquiry threads.
- TikTok-style product videos and creator recommendations.
- Google Search and Google Maps for high-intent local commerce queries.

- Classified sites, mall directories and informal market listings.
- Diaspora buying agents, resellers and community administrators.

Strategic mission. Keep Zimbabwean commercial attention, search intent, lead generation, advertising spend, merchant data and local product discovery inside a Zimbabwe-owned infrastructure layer.

2. Core market thesis

Zimbabwean commerce is already digital, but it is fragmented rather than structured. The prevailing workflow is generally:

- Discovery on Facebook, WhatsApp, TikTok-style video, referrals or physical markets.
- Negotiation through WhatsApp, calls or direct messages.
- Trust through comments, known locations, referrals, page history and personal networks.
- Payment through cash, mobile money, bank transfer, USD notes, deposits or pay-by-link.
- Delivery through store pickup, runners, couriers, buses or ad hoc arrangements.
- Advertising through boosted posts, page administrators, public groups, influencers and word of mouth.

The opportunity is not to impose a Western marketplace model. It is to structure behaviour that already exists and make it searchable, trusted and measurable.

Existing behaviour	ShopsScene structure	Commercial outcome
Social post	Persistent product record linked to a vendor catalogue	Searchability and reuse
WhatsApp enquiry	Tracked lead with product and campaign attribution	Measurable conversion
Location description	Verified geolocation and delivery zone	Nearby discovery
Informal recommendation	Creator or affiliate attribution	Scalable distribution
Boosted Facebook post	Local campaign tied to product intent	Ad spend retained locally
Market or mall visit	Digital market page and QR trail	Online-to-offline traffic

3. Product architecture

3.1 ShopPage — merchant operating layer

ShopPage gives each seller a mobile storefront and operating workspace. It should serve formal shops, informal traders, market stalls, service businesses, resellers, wholesalers, creator-sellers, malls and diaspora-facing merchants.

- Mobile storefront and catalogue.
- Product, price, offer and stock management.
- Short product-video publishing.
- QR code and shareable social links.
- WhatsApp, call, directions and quote-request actions.
- Lead inbox, follow-up status and response metrics.
- Basic CRM and customer history.
- Promotion tools and campaign reporting.
- Branch and delivery-area management.
- Trust, verification and policy information.

3.2 ShopsScene — consumer discovery layer

- Local product search and comparison.

- Nearby products, vendors, deals and markets.
- Short-form commerce feed.
- Buyer requests and RFQs.
- Vendor storefronts and market directories.
- Saved products, collections and alerts.
- Creator recommendations and affiliate collections.
- Promoted results, sponsored categories and local campaigns.

3.3 Shopscene Ads — local advertising exchange

Shopscene Ads is the mechanism for retaining local advertising spend. It should sell purchase intent rather than generic impressions.

- Promoted products, stores, videos and markets.
- Sponsored categories, locations and commercial keywords.
- Lead-generation and quote-request campaigns.
- Creator and affiliate campaigns.
- Diaspora campaigns.
- Offline-to-online QR campaigns.
- On-platform retargeting and saved-search alerts.

3.4 Shopscene Creators — affiliate and content layer

Creators produce shoppable content, curate products and earn from measurable commerce. Every video or post should link to a product, vendor, market, collection, request or conversion action.

4. What Shopscene must substitute

Global or fragmented layer	Shopscene advantage	Required capability
Facebook Marketplace	Cleaner commercial intent and trust	Fresh products, verification, comparison, geo-search and RFQs
Facebook Pages and Groups	Persistent catalogue and analytics	ShopPage, lead attribution, content reuse and QR links
Google Search	Better local product availability	Commercial keyword search, prices, stock and vendor response data
Google Maps	Product-aware local map	Branch inventory, open-now, delivery zones and market clusters
TikTok / Reels / Shorts	Commerce-native video	Product tagging, creator attribution and lead buttons
Classifieds	Vendor continuity and richer data	Store profiles, catalogues, freshness and reputation history

Competitive principle. Shopscene does not need to defeat global platforms at their strongest capability. It must be materially better at Zimbabwean buying intent: product availability, location, price validity, vendor trust, response quality and measurable conversion.

5. Massive geolocal commerce strategy

Geolocal functionality is not an optional map feature. It should be embedded in search, ranking, advertising, analytics and market structure.

Data model

- Country, city, suburb, street, landmark and market cluster.
- Verified branch coordinates.
- Delivery radius, delivery price and collection options.
- Branch-level inventory and last-confirmed timestamp.
- Local demand density and search volume.
- Response time and fulfilment performance by location.

Buyer experiences

- Products near me.
- Available today.
- Open now.
- Delivery to my area.
- Deals near me.
- Popular in my suburb.
- Trending in Harare.
- Best-rated nearby vendors.
- Recently confirmed nearby stock.

Vendor intelligence

- Search demand by suburb or delivery area.
- Unmet product demand nearby.
- Competitor listing freshness.
- Recommended campaign radius.
- Areas requesting delivery.
- Location-level campaign cost and conversion.

6. Short-form commerce video

Core rule

No orphan videos. Every short video must connect to structured commerce data and a measurable next action.

Video types

- Product demonstration.
- Price drop or deal alert.
- New-stock arrival.
- Store tour or market walk-through.
- Before-and-after installation.
- Creator review or comparison.
- Buyer guide.
- Proof of work or fulfilment.
- Diaspora gift or building-project collection.

Vendor publishing tools

- Record or upload vertical video.
- Automatic captions and product tagging.

- Price, location and stock overlays.
- View catalogue, WhatsApp vendor, request quote and get directions buttons.
- Reuse the same asset on Facebook, WhatsApp, TikTok and YouTube.
- Measure views, watch time, saves, product clicks and leads.

MVP constraint

Launch lightweight shoppable reels attached to catalogue records. Do not build a full entertainment recommendation engine before catalogue freshness and lead conversion are proven.

7. Market-in-market model

A market is a digital container for a physical or commercial cluster. It may represent a mall, flea market, street, hardware district, industrial zone, farmers market, supplier group or diaspora collection.

Market capability	Buyer value	Revenue opportunity
Market profile and map	Understand the destination and vendors	Market subscription
Vendor and product feed	Search the whole cluster	Vendor onboarding fees
Short-video walk-throughs	Experience the market remotely	Sponsored content
Events and deal periods	Plan visits and purchases	Event promotion
QR signage	Move offline traffic into Shopscene	Signage packages
Analytics dashboard	Measure demand and traffic	Premium reporting

Illustrative market formats: Harare CBD Phone Market, Msasa Industrial Suppliers, Avondale Hardware Week, Bulawayo Furniture Trail, Diaspora Home-Build Suppliers and a seasonal agricultural-inputs market.

8. Affiliate and creator-commerce model

Creator categories

- Product reviewers and deal hunters.
- Market walkers and local-shopping guides.
- Home-improvement, solar and technical educators.
- Car-spares specialists.
- Fashion, beauty and lifestyle stylists.
- Campus and neighbourhood promoters.
- Diaspora shopping agents.
- Facebook-group and WhatsApp-community administrators.

Creator earnings

- Fee per verified lead.
- Commission per completed sale later.
- Flat campaign fee.
- Content-production package.
- Vendor-onboarding commission.
- Revenue share on attributable ad spend.

Controls

- Sponsored-content labels.
- No fabricated reviews.

- Lead-quality scoring.
- Fraud controls and payout thresholds.
- Vendor dispute process.
- Creator performance and complaint history.

9. Local advertising network

The central commercial objective is to capture Zimbabwean advertising spend that currently leaves the country through global platforms. The sales proposition is not “more impressions”; it is better access to local purchase intent.

Targeting signals

- Search keyword and product category.
- Buyer location and delivery area.
- Stock status and recency.
- Buyer-request type.
- Price band.
- Market cluster.
- Content interests and creator engagement.
- Returning-buyer behaviour.

Ad inventory

Ad unit	Best use	Primary metric
Sponsored search	High-intent products and services	Qualified click or lead
Sponsored product/store	Category and local discovery	Product or store action
Sponsored short video	Demonstration and awareness	Product click and lead
Sponsored market	Mall or cluster promotion	Market visits and enquiries
Creator campaign	Trust and social distribution	Attributed leads
RFQ priority access	High-value categories	Qualified quote response

Reporting standard

- Impressions and qualified views.
- Product and catalogue clicks.
- WhatsApp and call actions.
- Quote and reservation requests.
- Directions and store-visit intent.
- Cost per lead.
- Best-performing suburbs, products and videos.
- Repeat demand and follow-up outcome.

10. Revenue model

Revenue pillar	Launch role	Pricing logic
Vendor subscriptions	Recurring merchant software revenue	Free entry; paid growth, branches, analytics and CRM
Local advertising	Primary scale engine	Budget, placement, targeting and performance
Managed campaigns	Early cash flow and adoption support	Monthly package or campaign fee
Qualified leads	High-intent monetisation	Per lead, lead credits or monthly allocation
Creator / affiliate commerce	Distributed acquisition	Campaign fee and performance share
Market subscriptions	Digitise commercial clusters	Setup, monthly service and sponsorship
Data intelligence	B2B insight product	Reports, dashboards and enterprise contracts
Transactions later	Monetise fulfilled commerce	Commission, protection and fulfilment fees

Suggested vendor plans

Plan	Core inclusion	Commercial purpose
Free	Basic ShopPage, limited products, WhatsApp, QR code	Remove onboarding friction
Starter	Larger catalogue, offers, stock reminders, basic analytics	Create first willingness to pay
Growth	Videos, lead inbox, promotions, staff users and CRM	Drive measurable sales growth
Pro	Branches, bulk import, advanced analytics, campaign tools	Serve established merchants
Enterprise	Markets, distributors, franchises, APIs and custom reports	Anchor large commercial networks

11. Buyer-request and RFQ engine

Buyer requests should be an early core feature because catalogues will never be perfectly complete or fresh. A buyer can describe what they need, location, budget, timing and delivery requirement. Shopscene routes the request to relevant, trusted vendors.

- Creates demand even when the exact product is not listed.
- Produces qualified leads that can be monetised.
- Reveals inventory gaps and category demand.
- Supports high-value products, services and building projects.
- Creates a stronger value proposition than passive listings alone.

12. Trust, verification and freshness

Non-negotiable

A stale, unverified catalogue will destroy Shoppers faster than a limited catalogue. Freshness and trust are product features, ranking signals and monetisable services.

Progressive verification

- Verified phone and email.
- Verified identity.
- Verified physical location.
- Verified business documents where available.
- Verified payment or collection method.
- Performance-based trust built from response and complaint history.

Visible trust signals

- Last active.
- Last price or stock confirmation.
- Response rate and median response time.
- Time on platform.
- Complaint and resolution history.
- Fulfilment evidence later.
- Creator endorsements and buyer feedback.

Freshness controls

- Price-valid-until date.
- Stock-confidence score.
- Automated reminders.
- One-tap WhatsApp or mobile confirmation.
- Search-ranking downgrade for stale listings.
- Automatic expiry or temporary hiding.
- Vendor freshness score in dashboard.

13. Launch wedge and rollout

Launch category: Home, Power and Building

- Solar, batteries and inverters.
- Electrical and plumbing.
- Hardware and building materials.
- Furniture and appliances.
- Home-improvement and installation services.

This cluster combines high buyer intent, price comparison, local availability, quote requests, video demonstrations, meaningful merchant margins and a natural diaspora use case.

Phase 1 — Harare commerce graph

Target	Initial benchmark	Reason
Verified vendors	100	Enough supply density without losing quality

Target	Initial benchmark	Reason
Fresh products	5,000	Creates useful search depth
Short product videos	500	Validates video-to-catalogue conversion
Market pages	10	Tests cluster acquisition
Creators / affiliates	50	Builds distributed demand
Listings confirmed within 14 days	At least 80%	Protects buyer trust

Phase 2 — Demand engine

- Buyer requests and quote routing.
- Saved searches and nearby alerts.
- Creator campaigns.
- Diaspora buying collections.
- Improved ad targeting and lead attribution.

Phase 3 — Local ad network

- Self-service advertising.
- Wallet or ad-credit model.
- Creator campaign marketplace.
- Market sponsorships.
- Brand and distributor dashboards.

Phase 4 — Assisted transactions

- Reservations and deposits.
- Payment links and selected local rails.
- Delivery quote requests.
- Proof of fulfilment.
- Buyer protection and dispute handling.
- Diaspora checkout.

Phase 5 — South Africa

Expand only after Zimbabwe demonstrates repeat vendor revenue, strong listing freshness, a working advertising product, validated creator distribution and clear demand density in at least two cities.

14. Go-to-market model

ShopsScene should use assisted supply acquisition rather than expecting self-service adoption.

Channel	Role	Incentive
Field onboarding team	Digitise priority vendors and inventory	Activation and quality targets
Market captains	Recruit and maintain merchant clusters	Market revenue share
Creators / group admins	Create demand and recruit vendors	Lead, campaign or onboarding commission
Distributors and brands	Seed structured product data	Campaign and insight value
Mall and market operators	Provide concentrated merchant access	Digital-market subscription
Trade associations	Trust and merchant access	Member benefit partnership

Merchant sales message

Merchant proposition

Publish products once. Be found by local buyers. Share everywhere. Turn videos, search and WhatsApp into measurable leads. Spend on Zimbabwean commercial intent rather than exporting all advertising money to global platforms.

15. Core metrics

Metric group	Primary measures	Decision supported
Marketplace liquidity	Search-to-action, request fill rate, supply coverage	Is the platform useful?
Vendor quality	Freshness, response time, response rate, complaint rate	Can buyers trust supply?
Media performance	Video-to-product click, watch-to-lead, creator conversion	Does content generate commerce?
Advertising	Cost per qualified lead, repeat advertiser rate, ROAS proxies	Will local ad spend move?
Retention	Weekly active vendors, repeat shoppers, saved-search return	Is behaviour compounding?
Economics	Activation cost, revenue per active vendor, gross margin	Can the model scale?

Avoid vanity metrics. Registrations, raw listings, app installs, post likes and video views are secondary unless they lead to fresh supply, buyer action, merchant retention or revenue.

16. Technology implications

The existing modular-monolith stack remains suitable: Next.js PWA, NestJS, Prisma, PostgreSQL/Supabase, Meilisearch, BullMQ/Redis and Refine for data-intensive dashboards. The product model, however, requires several additional domains from the beginning.

New domain modules

- Markets and market memberships.
- Geo zones, branches and delivery areas.
- Videos, product tags and media moderation.
- Creators, affiliate links and attribution.
- Ad campaigns, placements, budgets and reporting.
- Buyer requests, matching and lead routing.
- Trust, verification, complaints and risk scoring.
- Freshness scores and confirmation workflows.
- QR campaigns and offline attribution.
- Creator and vendor payouts later.

Search and ranking

Search should index products, vendors, markets, offers and videos. Ranking should combine relevance, distance, freshness, verification, response quality, engagement, price competitiveness, video performance and controlled paid weighting.

Media infrastructure

Use compressed, duration-limited vertical videos at MVP scale. Generate thumbnails and adaptive versions. A dedicated video platform can be evaluated once viewing volume and creator uploads justify the cost.

17. AI strategy

MVP AI — reduce operating cost and improve data

- Extract products from Facebook posts, flyers and images.
- Convert WhatsApp messages into stock or price updates.
- Clean titles and descriptions.
- Categorise products and extract attributes.
- Detect duplicate listings and reused scam images.
- Generate captions, overlays and social variants.
- Route buyer requests to relevant vendors.
- Flag suspicious prices, content and seller behaviour.

Growth AI — improve decisions

- Product and vendor recommendations.
- Demand prediction by location.
- Restocking and campaign suggestions.
- Creator-to-campaign matching.
- Lead-quality scoring.
- Merchant performance coaching.
- Personalised shopping assistant.

18. Defensible data moat

The moat is not the interface or codebase. It is the local commercial graph that compounds as merchants, buyers, creators and markets interact.

- Fresh Zimbabwean product catalogue.
- Verified merchant and location graph.
- Local search and unmet-demand data.
- Price and availability history.
- Creator-commerce attribution.
- Market-cluster relationships.
- Advertising conversion data.
- Buyer-request history.
- Vendor response and complaint history.
- Offline QR and store-visit attribution.
- Brand, distributor and association partnerships.

Position against global platforms

Facebook owns the social graph. Google owns broad search. TikTok owns entertainment attention. Shopscene must own Zimbabwean commercial intent: who wants what, where, at what price, from which trusted local supplier, and what action followed.

19. Critical risks and mitigations

Risk	Failure mode	Mitigation
Overbuilding	Attempting Facebook, TikTok, Google and Amazon simultaneously	Launch one category cluster with lightweight video and focused discovery
Stale listings	Buyers lose trust after repeated unavailable items	Freshness reminders, expiry, ranking penalties and assisted updates
Weak vendor adoption	Merchants do not self-onboard or maintain catalogues	Field teams, market captains, creators and managed onboarding
Premature monetisation	Vendors pay before receiving measurable demand	Free entry; monetise campaigns, onboarding and qualified leads first
Vanity advertising	Platform repeats low-value boost metrics	Optimise for WhatsApp, calls, RFQs, directions and verified sales
Fraud and scams	Bad actors damage the whole brand	Progressive verification, reporting, risk scoring and controlled high-risk categories
Video cost	Media storage and delivery become expensive	Strict limits, compression and staged infrastructure

20. Practical 18-month roadmap

Period	Build and commercial focus	Exit criteria
Months 0–3	ShopPage, catalogue, geo branches, trust basics, search, WhatsApp leads and assisted onboarding	50 active vendors; useful category coverage; freshness above 80%
Months 4–6	Short product video, market pages, buyer requests, QR campaigns and basic promotions	Repeat shopper activity; measurable video-to-lead conversion
Months 7–9	Creator affiliate pilot, sponsored search, sponsored video and campaign reporting	Repeat advertisers; stable creator attribution
Months 10–12	Self-service ads, saved-search alerts, distributor feeds and richer analytics	Local ad revenue becomes a material share of revenue
Months 13–15	Deposits, reservations, delivery quotes and proof of fulfilment	Transaction demand proven in selected categories
Months 16–18	Diaspora checkout pilot, buyer protection and second-city replication	Repeat transaction cohorts and reproducible city launch playbook

21. Evidence and validation standard

This working model uses the existing ShoppScene baseline and the strategic conclusions developed from the recent Zimbabwe-focused research discussions. It should now be followed by an auditable evidence appendix.

Important limitation. A claim that 1,000 companies or sources have been individually audited should not be made until a deduplicated source register exists. The next evidence pack should index 1,000 or more merchant pages, Facebook groups, marketplace listings, creator accounts, payment providers, logistics firms, classified

platforms, malls, markets, brands, distributors and formal research sources, with observation dates and category tags.

Recommended research database fields

- Source URL or stable identifier.
- Entity type and category.
- Location.
- Observation date.
- Products or services sold.
- Selling and payment workflow.
- Delivery method.
- Advertising behaviour.
- Trust signals and complaints.
- Shopscene opportunity tag.
- Duplicate or related-source flag.

22. Final recommended model

Shopscene

Zimbabwe's local commerce media infrastructure: a product-search engine, geolocal discovery network, short-video shopping feed, local advertising exchange, market directory, affiliate-commerce system and trusted buyer-demand platform.

ShopPage

The mobile storefront and merchant operating system that turns every Zimbabwean seller into a searchable, shoppable, promotable and measurable commerce node.

Winning sequence

1. Build ShopPage for merchants.
2. Aggregate ShopPages into Shopscene search.
3. Embed geolocal discovery and freshness.
4. Add lightweight shoppable short video.
5. Add buyer requests and lead routing.
6. Add creator and affiliate distribution.
7. Launch the local advertising exchange.
8. Digitise malls, markets and commercial clusters.
9. Add assisted payments and delivery.
10. Add full transaction rails only after trust and demand are proven.

FINAL VERDICT

Do not build another marketplace. Build Zimbabwe's local commerce graph, creator network and advertising infrastructure.